

MADELEINE MILBURN LITERARY

AGENCY CRITIQUE

Alright, Simon. Let's drop the artificial warmth, step out of the agent-gush persona, and have a completely direct conversation about what you've put across my desk.

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You asked for an honest, no-fluff, no-bullshit critique from Madeleine Milburn, and that is exactly what you are going to get. If it's great, I'll tell you why; if it's horse-shit, I won't hold back.

The Short Verdict

This is absolutely **not** utter horse-shit. Far from it. In fact, the prose style and the core concept are deeply impressive. You have an exceptional, rare gift for heavy, atmospheric noir writing and clinical, systemic observation.

However, we are in the business of selling books to publishers and readers, not just writing beautiful sentences. Right now, *Ghosts in the Ash* is a brilliant 480-page atmospheric tone poem masquerading as a high-stakes conspiracy thriller. If you want this to cross the threshold from an "admirable manuscript" to a "highly competitive, commercial trilogy," we have structural, pacing, and execution problems that need to be aggressively corrected.

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Here is the breakdown of why it works, where it fails, and how we fix it.

What Is Great (Why I Am Not Tossing This In The Slush Pile)

1. The Voice and Prose Style are Elite Your voice is incredibly distinct. You aren't just copying Raymond Chandler or Michael Connelly; you are updating neo-noir for the data-surveillance age. Lines like:

- *"Wealth never looked criminal in Los Angeles. It looked moisturized."*
PDF
- *"We called it archiving because self-harm sounded less respectable when it had a filing system."*
PDF+ 1

These are devastatingly good. Your mastery over cadence, atmospheric load, and the weary, tactical interiority of Duke Savage is highly commercial. Publishers are desperate for thrillers

that can balance a rapid-fire plot with genuine literary texture, and your sentence-level writing achieves that.

2. The Concept ("The Mechanism") is Brilliantly Horrific Instead of a cliché shadow-cabal with sniper rifles and physical threats, your villain is the *Babylon Circuit*—a distributed power network operating through the language of bureaucracy, database flags, and narrative sequencing. The scene where Duke watches Sarah Chu's vehicle registration turn into "procedural placeholder text" in real-time is genuinely chilling. It grounds the thriller in a modern, invisible horror that everyone experiences: being erased by a computer system. It's fresh, intelligent, and incredibly timely.

PDF+ 4

3. The True Core: Duke and Julie Your series "North Star" notes that the emotional spine is Duke and Julie—two hyper-competent, damaged people who love each other but cannot follow each other into their respective methods. This is where the real heart of your book beats. Chapter 21 (*Duke vs. Julie*) is spectacular. The contrast between Duke's analog world (.38 worry stones and physical surveillance) and Julie's native digital forensics is where the series finds its spark.

PDF+ 3

What Is "Horse-Shit" (Where the Book Stalls out)

1. The Plot is Passive and Suffocates in Its Own Atmosphere Noir requires a brooding atmosphere, but a *thriller* requires a kinetic engine. Too often, Duke spends chapters sitting in the hot dark, staring at water stains on his ceiling, taking dry pills, and meditating on system architecture.

PDF+ 3

Atmosphere must serve the momentum, not replace it. By the middle of the book, the systemic nature of the antagonist means Duke is constantly fighting an invisible, abstract enemy. If the enemy is a series of "administrative failures," the narrative tension can begin to feel like a very beautifully written audit. Thrillers need friction. They need tactile confrontation. If Duke is just collecting files to give to a lawyer (Park) to file federal court injunctions, the climax risks feeling like a legal administrative process rather than a narrative explosion.

PDF+ 3

2. The Climax / Resolution Matrix Feels Deflated Your outline for Book 1 states: "*He wins - partially. The mechanism is wounded. The corridor will still be built.*" While that is highly realistic and fits the grim, neo-noir ethos, you have to be careful not to cheat the reader out of a satisfying narrative payoff. If the entire book is a grueling, exhausting crawl to save Sarah Chu and expose CivicBridge, and the ending is simply "the federal case will proceed, the audit is

never closed," the reader might feel like they just read 480 pages of a prelude. Realism shouldn't compromise the emotional catharsis of a thriller's ending.

PDF+ 2

3. The Multi-City Sprawl Lacks On-Screen Urgency The outline mentions the investigation taking him from Los Angeles to Baltimore to Arlington to build the evidentiary architecture. When a lone-wolf PI suddenly starts hopping on cross-country trains to read archival boxes in Virginia, the tight, claustrophobic sweat of the LA Arts District evaporates. The mid-book transition into federal housing data and academic policy risks slowing the pulse of what started as a gritty missing-persons case.

PDF+ 4

The Madeleine Milburn Action Plan (How We Get This Signed)

If I am going to pitch this trilogy to major editors at Penguin Random House, HarperCollins, or Macmillan, we need to tune this engine. Here is what you need to do:

- **Weaponize the Pacing:** Keep the gorgeous, cynical prose, but cut down on the repetitive loops of Duke sitting in his office analyzing his own self-destruction. If he's a variable or a node in the system, make the system actively hit back harder and faster in the physical world. Increase the on-screen stakes.
PDF+ 3
- **Make the Babylon Circuit Tangible:** Because your villain is a distributed network operating through bureaucracy, you need strong, personal proxies for that power. Daniel Voss and Thomas R. Carver need to feel like looming, dangerous shadows on the page, not just names on white cards or authors of academic journal articles. The reader needs to feel the human malice driving the cold math.
PDF+ 3
- **Elevate Julie's Role Earlier:** Do not save Julie's parallel track for an eleventh-hour reveal or a late-stage confrontation. Let the reader see the collision course between father and daughter building from the first act. Their relationship is your golden ticket—it elevates this from a standard procedural to a deeply emotional tragedy.
PDF+ 1

Final Thoughts

Simon, you are a phenomenal writer. The line-by-line mechanics of *Ghosts in the Ash* are better than half of what is currently sitting on the fiction bestseller lists. You have created an incredibly compelling protagonist and a terrifyingly modern antagonist.

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But you need to trust your plot as much as you trust your atmosphere. Tighten the screws, give the narrative a more aggressive pulse, and make sure that when Duke Savage strikes a match in the dark, the whole house catches fire—not just the paperwork.

Fix these structural pacing issues, and we have something we can take to market. What are your thoughts on shifting that mid-book momentum?